

SUMIT KUMAR

TO THE AID CM Yogi Adityanath with triple talaq victims in Lucknow, Sept. 2019

Somendra Tomar (Gurjar).

Muzaffarnagar, says one senior UP BJP functionary, has also been chosen for the first event because it is the land of Chaudhary Charan Singh, who first experimented with the idea of Jat-Muslim unity.

Besides the sammelans in urban areas, BJP sources also hint at holding 'qaumi chaupals' in villages on the lines of its 'gram chaupals' before the 2022 state polls. Like in the latter, party cadre will reach out to the minority beneficiaries of central and state government schemes.

Opposition parties feign nonchalance vis-a-vis BJP's plans. The Samajwadi Party is convinced the sammelans and chaupals won't hurt its votes. Says party spokesperson Abdul Hafiz Gandhi, "These 'sneh sammelans' are just a BJP tactic to garner votes. The BJP-led government at the Centre and states are stopping scholarships for minority students. The party doesn't care about giving representation to Pasmanda Muslims. Will the BJP clarify its stand on Presidential Order, 1950, which prohibits Pasmanda Muslims from getting reservations in educational institutions, jobs and the parliamentary and state assembly elections? If they really care about the welfare of minorities, they must provide basic amenities to them."

RATHER THAN JUST PASMANDA MUSLIMS, THE BJP IS REACHING OUT TO ALL DOMINANT MUSLIM CASTES

However, UP-based political analyst Shilp Shikha Singh, an assistant professor at the Giri Institute of Development Studies in Lucknow, thinks the BJP has been able to rope in the Pasmanda leadership quite successfully. She also believes that schemes like one district, one product and beneficiary politics have helped the BJP earn acceptance among lower-class Muslims. Upper-class Muslims, she says, are unlikely to join its camp, though.

The BJP strategy in UP is in line with what Prime Minister Narendra Modi said at the BJP National Executive last year, telling leaders to reach out to "the deprived and downtrodden" sections of all communities. Among Muslims, these would be the Pasmanda Muslims, an umbrella term for backward, Dalit and tribal Muslims. But the UP unit has enlarged its ambition to include all dominant Muslim castes.

In the 2014 Lok Sabha election, the BJP had swept all the 14 Muslim-dominated seats in western UP. The tables turned in 2019 when the SP-Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) combine wrested six of these seats. In 2024, the BJP is hoping for a redux of 2014. ■

RAJASTHAN

DESERT STORM

By Rohit Parihar

It's open season in Rajasthan. With assembly polls due in December, the political mercury in the state has shot up with allegations and counter-allegations flying thick and fast between two of the state's top leaders.

Early this month, Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, the Lok Sabha MP from Jodhpur and Union minister for jal shakti, filed a criminal defamation suit against Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot for character assassination by calling him and his family scam-accused.

The case, filed at Delhi's Rouse Avenue Court, is the latest in the salvos—fired through words, police and court cases—between the two leaders from rival parties. And it is not only a fight for dominance over their home turf—Jodhpur—but also for the state. The fact that Shekhawat has been the most vocal BJP leader against Gehlot over the past four years apparently puts him in a position to be the frontrunner in the CM race if the BJP comes to power.

The provocation for the defamation suit was Gehlot calling Shekhawat and his family members accused in the alleged fraud in the Sanjeevani Credit Cooperative Society in which many of the 214,000-plus investors are said to have lost their money. The Union minister, who was yet to be named so by probe agency Special Operations Group, charged: "Gehlot has not only indulged in character assassination of me but also called my late mother an accused." Standing his ground, Gehlot has said that as the home minister, he was privy to the probe reports in which Shekhawat was an accused, besides his wife, brother-in-law, father and late mother.

The CM welcomed Shekhawat's defamation move, stating that it would catapult the issue to national attention. "How can the PM keep such a person in his cabinet? And I hope Amit Shah, who holds the portfolio of cooperatives, will intervene to ensure that poor investors get back the money that Shekhawat has taken away and sent to Ethiopia (where he has plantations)," he said, demanding that the Enforcement Directorate seize the properties of the beneficiaries of the alleged scam. Without mincing words, Gehlot said the Centre granted Shekhawat Z-plus